

Canal, Grid and Clock: Sapporo on the Toyohira Fan

Before it was a grid, this ground was a fan of gravel where a shogunate farm dug an irrigation ditch. Judges, an American professor and a beer brewery turned that ditch into a capital's spine. This dossier follows the canal, the firebreak and the bell tower from 1857 to the park that reopened above the river in 2011.



札幌都心（時計台・創成川）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (7 chapters, about 1900 words)
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

Two Names for One River

Sapporo's city government offers two explanations for its own name and says both are right. Where the Toyohira River spreads its gravel across open ground, the Ainu called the place *sat poro*, "the dry, vast place"; where the same river's lower course meets the Ishikari River in reed and marsh, it was *sari poro pet*, "the place of the great wetland." The upper fan is genuinely dry, the lower stretch genuinely wet, and the modern grid sits on the fan, on ground the Toyohira River built by dropping its gravel as it slowed onto the plain.¹²

How long people lived on that fan before anyone wrote it down, Sapporo's own 1911 district history could not say: it records scattered Ainu villages and stone tools turned up by later farmers, and leaves their age open. What it dates precisely is the moment officialdom first marked the ground for settlement: the twenty-fourth day of the second month of Ansei 4, 1857, when the Hakodate magistrate Muragaki Awaji-no-kami Norimasa set aside Sapporo's forest for shogunate retainers, opened a road toward Chitose and sent farmers to nearby Hassamu. When a Colonization Commission judge finally rode in twelve years later, he found the site empty but for two men, ferrymen named Shinmura Tetsuichi and Yoshida Mohachi, camped by the Toyohira crossing since the 1850s.¹³

A Shogunate Farm and the Ditch That Outlasted It

The first person to build anything permanent on this ground was not a Colonization Commission official but a shogunate land agent, Ōtomo Kametarō (大友亀太郎), who worked by the agronomist Ninomiya Sontoku's methods. Ordered by the Hakodate magistrate to develop land near Sapporo, he explored the area with a local guide in 1866 and chose a plain thick with oak trees at what is now Higashi Ward's Motomura, close enough to the Toyohira River for irrigation and firm enough underfoot to build on. He brought in farming households ten at a time, cleared more than forty *chō* of fields in three years, and by his own account governed his settlers strictly but excused their taxes for a decade.¹⁴

To water his fields and his settlers, Ōtomo hired a foreman named Kurotaki Daijirō and dug an irrigation channel now known as Ōtomo-bori (大友堀): about half a metre deep and six *shaku* — some 1.8 metres — wide at the top, narrowing toward the bed, running from near today's Minami 3-jō north to Minami 6-jō before bending away to the Fushiko River. The work took only months. After the Meiji Restoration, Ōtomo handed his post to a War Ministry official and left for Tōbetsu; but his ditch stayed in the ground, and its north-south line — not any survey the new government later commissioned — became the axis the whole future city was built along.¹⁴

Judge Shima's Winter

Officialdom arrived in earnest in November 1869. Judge Shima Yoshitake (島義勇) rode in from a temporary office at Zenibako, staked out the town's ropes on the eleventh and twelfth of that month at what is now south of Ōdori, and put up the settlement's first government building on the Sosei riverside, near today's Toyohira-kan site, using Nanbu-region carpenters and Zenibako fishermen he pressed into service when local labour ran out. Snow buried each day's work by the next morning; his men laid straw mats to protect the timbers and stripped elm bark to feed the horses when fodder ran short. Shima's own tenure lasted only three months, but Sapporo's district history credits him with the bold, oversized plan that his successors had no choice but to fill: town blocks three *chō* square, main roads three *ken* wide.¹³

Shima's Sapporo also collided with the War Ministry, which controlled the neighbouring Ishikari district and had its own plan for the newly surrendered Aizu domain: by October 1869 it had already shipped some two hundred households, more than seven hundred people, to Otaru, intending to settle them at Sapporo itself. When the Colonization Commission's jurisdiction prevailed instead, the War Ministry redirected its Aizu settlers to found Tōbetsu, a little to the north — one of several quiet decisions that shaped which nearby town absorbed the old regime's defeated retainers and which one became the capital.¹

Shima's successor, Judge Iwamura Michitoshi (岩村通俊), inherited the ditch as much as the plan. In 1870 an official named Sasaki Kanzō proposed widening Ōtomo's channel for boat traffic rather than digging a new canal from scratch; Iwamura agreed, and workers deepened it north to the Kotoni River confluence and south past Minami 7-jō, a stretch later called Yoshida-bori after its subcontractor — Yoshida Mohachi, the same ferryman Shima had found camping at the Toyohira crossing. Iwamura also surveyed a broad east-west firebreak, twelve *ken* (about 22 metres) wide, separating the government quarter to its north from the merchants' quarter to its south; renamed for Hokkaido's old provinces in 1872 and stripped of that scheme in 1881, Shiribeshi-dōri became simply Ōdori, the avenue that still divides the city today. The channel itself was renamed the Sosei River in 1874.^{14 57}

An American Professor for a Capital of Farmers

Kuroda Kiyotaka, who would come to lead the whole colonisation project, went further than any predecessor to find outside help. He sent seven Japanese students abroad to study, and through the Japanese minister in Washington, Mori Arinori, he recruited Horace Capron, the United States Commissioner of Agriculture and an army major general, as chief foreign adviser. The two men's surviving letters, quoted at length in Sapporo's 1911 history, show Mori laying out Hokkaido's size and resources in careful, formal prose and Capron answering with a list of conditions — an annual salary, an interpreter, a house — before he would agree to come.¹

Capron's recommendations led, in 1876, to Sapporo Agricultural College, and to the year its own graduates would remember longest. William S. Clark, on leave from the presidency of the Massachusetts Agricultural College, arrived that August with two of his own graduates as junior instructors and stayed only a single year. In that year, by his students' own account, he set the school's tone: he gathered them for Bible readings and prayer every morning although religious instruction was not on the syllabus, over Director Kuroda's objections, and told them bluntly at the opening ceremony that Japan needed capable people and that they, its first class, would have to become them. When he left he is remembered for four words of farewell — "Boys, be ambitious" — which the college kept as its unofficial motto for a century after.¹

The new capital's spiritual centre moved in step with its physical one. Three guardian deities of colonisation had already been enshrined in Tokyo in September 1869 and carried north by Judges Higashikuze and Shima; after a temporary home near today's Kita 2-jō, the shrine settled permanently at Maruyama in September 1871, took the name Sapporo Shrine that year, and was not renamed Hokkaido Shrine, with the Meiji Emperor added as a fourth deity, until 1964 — a reminder of how gradually a frontier settlement's institutions became a prefecture's, then a nation's.⁸

The Capital Fills In

Through the 1870s and 1880s, government-run enterprises gave the grid its economy. A brewery the Colonization Commission opened on 23 September 1876 — the first full-scale beer brewery in Japan built and run entirely by Japanese hands, according to its own corporate history — became, after later reorganisation, the direct ancestor of today's Sapporo Beer; a hemp and linen mill followed in 1888. A railway guide published in 1938 could still describe the city, by then two hundred thousand strong, as sitting "like a go board" in the plain's south-west corner, its main streets lined with the acacia trees planted in those decades, its brewery and mill still turning out beer, sailcloth and yarn for the whole prefecture.⁹¹¹

For visiting dignitaries the Commission built Toyohira-kan (豊平館) in 1880, a wooden Western-style hotel completed that December with a lawn and curved paths laid out in front by the American adviser Louis Boehmer using flowers raised at the Agricultural College's own greenhouse; the Meiji Emperor lodged there during his 1881 tour of Hokkaido, the first of three imperial generations to do so. The same year, in the Agricultural College's drill hall nearby, a pendulum clock ordered from the Boston firm E. Howard & Co. began keeping time for the whole town; the tower still carries it today, and Sapporo made it the city's official standard clock in 1888.¹⁰¹²¹³²⁰

When the college moved to a larger campus in 1903, Sapporo borrowed its old drill hall as a public hall and library, and only then did people start calling the building simply the Clock Tower. A red-brick prefectural office building of 1888, its walls said to hold some two and a half million bricks, rose a few streets away as the same government outgrew its wooden Meiji offices — a second, sturdier landmark for the same young capital.¹⁰¹⁸

War at the Edges, a River Rebuilt

Sapporo was not a target of the incendiary raids that burned Japan's larger cities, but it was not untouched. On 14 and 15 July 1945, American aircraft strafed and bombed the army airfield at Okadama, an oil depot at Teine-Karugawa — seven tanks burned for three days — and the rail yards at Shiroishi, all on the city's edges rather than in the central grid; the city's own peace archive names one civilian killed in the attacks, a farmer strafed in his fields, and his wounded son.¹⁴

Sapporo's next transformation came from an Olympics. Chosen to host the Eleventh Winter Games, the city opened its first subway line — the Namboku Line, twelve kilometres from Kita 24-jō to Makomanai — on 16 December 1971, together with an underground shopping street downtown, both built as Olympic infrastructure according to the city's own Olympic museum; the Games' opening ceremony followed on 3 February 1972 at the Makomanai outdoor stadium, before athletes from thirty-five countries. The Games also left central Sapporo a problem it would spend decades solving: a Sosei River now boxed in by a four-lane road and two car underpasses that cut the east side of downtown off from the west.⁵¹⁵¹⁶

The fix came in 2011, when the city finished linking those underpasses and returned the surface above them to people rather than cars, opening Sosei River Park along both banks. A neighbourhood association's 1967 monument marking Sapporo's founding site, until then

wedged into a building lot nearby, was moved into the new park at the foot of Sosei-bashi — the same bridge Judge Iwamura named in 1871, over the same channel Ōtomo Kametarō had dug as an irrigation ditch a century and a half before. ⁵¹⁷

Reading the Ground Today

Stand at the corner of Ōdori and the Sosei River and the whole sequence is underfoot: the firebreak axis running east-west, the canal-turned-river running north-south, exactly where Iwamura's surveyors and Ōtomo's ditch-diggers left them. The Clock Tower, moved a hundred metres south in 1906 for road works but otherwise little changed, still keeps the time its Boston-made pendulum has kept since 1881. A few streets north, the red-brick former government building reopened in July 2025 after roughly five years of restoration, its exhibits now including new digital displays on Ainu culture alongside the colonial-era offices. ^{57 10 18} ⁵¹⁷

Two blocks east, Nijo Market still trades on the site where Ishikari-coast fishermen once tied up their boats on the Sosei's bank to sell the morning's catch; a thirteen-shop fish sellers' union formed there in the Meiji era survived an 1902 fire and grew into the market that still calls itself the city's kitchen. None of the timber buildings of 1869 survive above ground, but the lines they were set out on — the ditch, the firebreak, the three-*ken* roads — are the lines the modern city still keeps its address grid on. ¹¹⁹

Timeline

1857	Hakodate magistrate Muragaki Norimasa sets aside Sapporo's forest for shogunate retainer settlement. ¹
1866	Ōtomo Kametarō settles farming households at Motomura and digs the irrigation channel later called Ōtomo-bori. ¹⁴
1869 (Sept.)	The three guardian deities of colonisation are enshrined in Tokyo, the origin of Sapporo (later Hokkaido) Shrine. ⁸
1869 (10 Nov.)	Judge Shima Yoshitake begins building the new capital at Sapporo. ¹³
1869–70	The War Ministry, denied jurisdiction over Sapporo, redirects its Aizu-domain settlers to found Tōbetsu instead. ¹
1871	Judge Iwamura Michitoshi surveys the grid and the Ōdori firebreak; Kuroda Kiyotaka travels abroad and hires Horace Capron. ¹⁷
1874	The widened Ōtomo-bori is renamed the Sosei River. ^{4 5}
1876	Sapporo Agricultural College opens under William S. Clark; the Colonization Commission's brewery, ancestor of Sapporo Beer, opens on 23 September. ¹¹¹
1880–81	Toyohira-kan is built for state guests; a Boston-made pendulum clock begins ringing in the Agricultural College's drill hall. ^{10 12 13}
1903–06	The Agricultural College moves; its old drill hall, borrowed by the city, becomes known as the Clock Tower and is later moved 100 m south. ¹⁰
1945 (14–15 Jul.)	American air raids hit Sapporo's edges at Okadama, Teine and Shiroishi. ¹⁴
1971–72	The Namboku subway line and an underground mall open for the Winter Olympics, whose opening ceremony is held on 3 February 1972. ^{15 16}
2011	Sosei River Park opens above the reconnected underpasses; the 1967 founding monument is moved into it. ^{5 17}

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

Sapporo Clock Tower 札幌市時計台. Look up at the pendulum clock, made by Boston's E. Howard & Co. and running since 1881, inside the Agricultural College's 1878 drill hall; displays inside recall its move 100 m south in 1906 and its years as the city's library.¹¹⁰
- 2

Former Hokkaido Government Building (Red Brick) 北海道庁旧本庁舎（赤れんが庁舎）. An 1888 brick office building, reopened in July 2025 after a five-year restoration, with new exhibits on Hokkaido's colonisation, including Ainu culture, alongside the original government rooms.¹⁸
- 3

Ōdori Park at the Sosei crossing 大通公園（創成川通交差点）. Stand where Ōdori meets the Sosei River: the east-west line underfoot is Iwamura's 1871 firebreak, the north-south watercourse is Ōtomo Kametarō's 1866 irrigation ditch, enlarged and renamed in 1874.⁵⁷
- 4

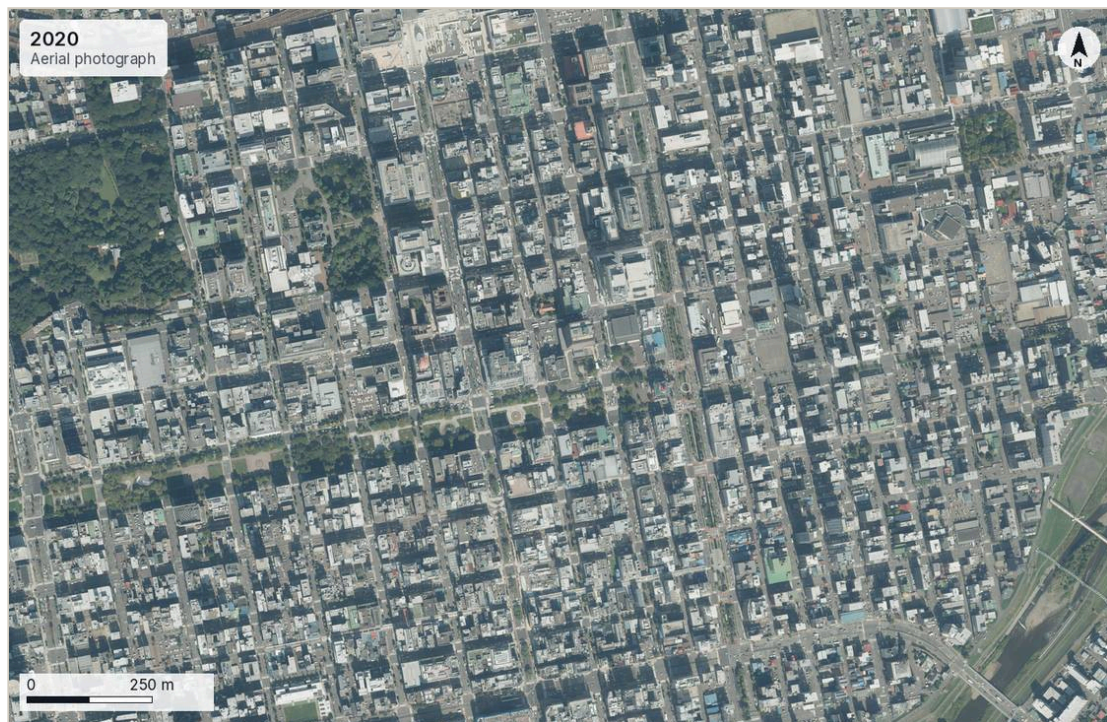
Sosei River Park and the "Sapporo Construction Site" monument 創成川公園・札幌建設の地碑. At the foot of Sosei-bashi, a black granite monument raised by a neighbourhood association in 1967 and moved here when the park opened in 2011 marks where Judge Shima's first government building stood in 1869.^{15 17}
- 5

Nijo Market 二条市場. A working fish and produce market on the Sosei's east bank, tracing its trade to Meiji-era fishermen who rowed catches up the river, and to a thirteen-shop union formed soon after; rebuilt following an 1902 fire.¹⁹

The same ground, 1945–1950 and 2020



1945–1950 aerial photograph (US military photography) — GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2020 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2020*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

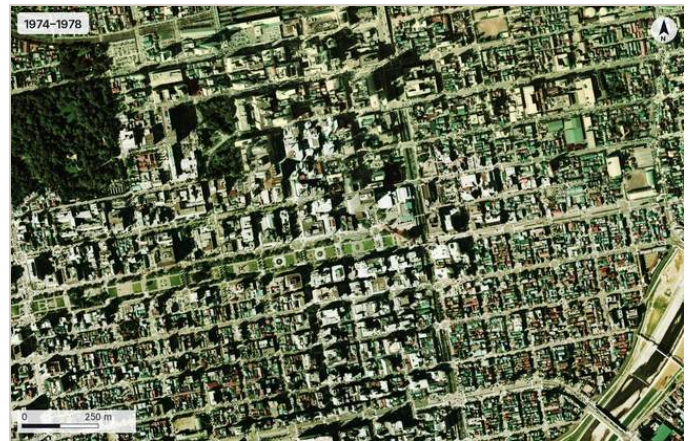
How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

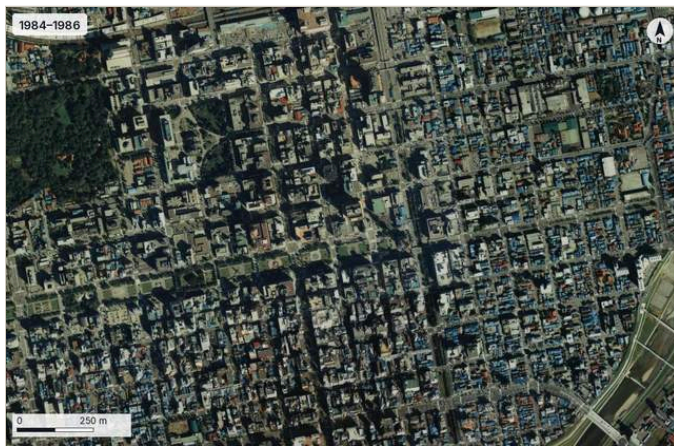
Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1961–1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed



1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1984–1986 · GSI Tiles *gazo3*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

■ Alluvial fan 93%	■ Former river channel 3.1%
■ Water 1.4%	■ Floodplain and coastal plain 0.6%

What the main landforms mean

Alluvial fan (93%). Gently sloping ground spreading fan-like from a valley mouth, built from sediment dropped by floods. Floodwater from the mountains, and debris flows near the valley mouth. Relatively firm ground; a slight liquefaction tendency on the lower fan.

Former river channel (3.1%). A former course of a river, slightly lower than its surroundings, cut off when the river moved and later filled with sand and mud. Floodwater stays longer and drains poorly; soft ground amplifies shaking; where filled or raised, the liquefaction tendency is very strong.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.

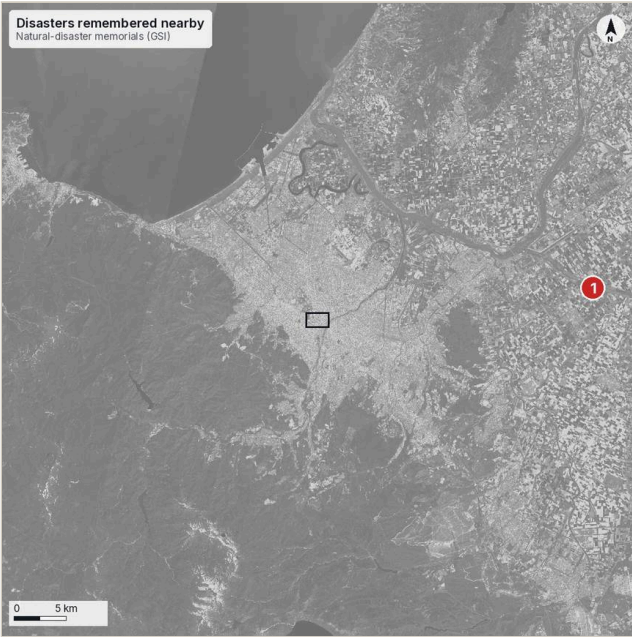
Man-made ground

No man-made ground mapped in this frame.

Meiji-era lowland

GSI has not traced Meiji-era lowland for this frame.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 60 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 30 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Monument of gratitude for the Yubari River flood-control works 治水感謝の碑	Floods of 7 Sep 1898 and Aug–Sep 1932, and others · flood	2004	26.3 km

What the memorials record

1. Monument of gratitude for the Yubari River flood-control works. The Yubari River caused severe disasters, including the floods of 1898 and August 1932. Flood-control works begun in 1920 and completed in 1936 turned the area into a town where people can enjoy the water in peace. The monument thanks those who carried out the works; beside it stands another honouring their achievement.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

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Further reading

- **新札幌市史 第1巻 通史1 (札幌市, 1989)** — Sapporo's current, far more detailed multi-volume city history (1989–2007), covering the Ainu era and the Colonization Commission period in depth this dossier could not match. <https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/search?cs=bib&keyword=%E6%96%B0%E6%9C%AD%E5%B9%8C%E5%B8%82%E5%8F%B2%E7%AC%AC1%E5%B7%BB%E9%80%9A%E5%8F%B21> (print only)
- **札幌市史 政治行政篇 (札幌市, 1953)** — The earlier official city history's chapter on Meiji-era administration; municipal librarians cite it when answering questions on episodes such as the Colonization Commission office fire. <https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/books/R100000002-I000000872370> (print only)
- **さっぽろ文庫 (札幌市教育委員会 編, multiple volumes, 1978–)** — A long-running series of short, well-illustrated local-history volumes that Sapporo's central library repeatedly draws on for questions about the Clock Tower, individual streets and the Colonization Commission era. <https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/search?cs=bib&keyword=%E3%81%95%E3%81%A3%E3%81%BD%E3%82%8D%E6%96%87%E5%BA%AB> (print only)
- **札幌沿革史 (札幌史学会 著, 北海道出版企画センター復刊, 1979)** — A modern reprint of the 1897 history used in this dossier as S3, easier to find in libraries outside the NDL Digital Collections. <https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/books/R100000002-I000001432470> (print only)

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Colonization Commission internal records on Judge Shima's recall and the Sapporo/Ishikari jurisdiction dispute with the War Ministry** — National Archives of Japan (開拓使公文録, Meiji 2–3) and the Hokkaido Prefectural Archives (北海道立文書館). Search the National Archives' digital catalogue by record group and date, or request the equivalent Hokkaido Prefectural Archives holdings in person.
- **Ōtomo Kametarō's own papers and the original, pre-20th-century course of Ōtomo-bori before later infilling** — Sapporo City Archives (札幌市公文書館) and the Sapporo Clock Tower's own history room (札幌市時計台 歴史展示室). Consult their reading rooms; ask for the background research files kept for the 新札幌市史 project.
- **The full Mori Arinori–Horace Capron correspondence on hiring foreign advisers, beyond the excerpts quoted in the 1911 district history** — Hokkaido University Archives (北海道大学大学文書館), which holds papers from the Clark and Capron era. Search the university archive's manuscript catalogue and request access through its reading room.
- **A fuller casualty and damage record for the July 1945 air raids on Sapporo, beyond the single named case in the city's peace museum** — The city's Peace Virtual Museum office and Hokkaido Shimbun's archive; US National Archives (NARA), 20th Air Force mission reports. Ask the museum office for its underlying source list; search NARA's catalogue by unit and date for the relevant mission reports.
- **Archaeological and settlement evidence for the Ainu-era ground beneath today's central grid, before the 1857 and 1866 decisions** — Sapporo Board of Education's buried-cultural-property division (埋蔵文化財) and Hokkaido University's Ainu and Indigenous Studies Center. Request site survey reports (発掘調査報告書) for known sites within the central wards; contact the Ainu and Indigenous Studies Center for published research on the same ground.

Caveats

- Two official sources give slightly different years for Toyohira-kan's move to Nakajima Park (dismantled in 1957 per one account, "moved in May 1958" per another); this dossier follows both, as dismantled in 1957 and reassembled by 1958.
- Ōtomo-bori's original depth is recorded in the 1911 district history in a form of shaku/sun notation that this dossier reads as roughly half a metre; the source is not fully unambiguous on this single figure.
- Casualty figures for the July 1945 air raids are incomplete in the sources read here: the city's Peace Virtual Museum names one civilian death, not a comprehensive toll for all three targets.
- Pre-1857 Ainu settlement within today's central grid is described only in general terms (scattered villages, stone tools) by the 1911 district history used here; it does not identify exact sites, which would need the archaeological leads listed above.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. This experimental edition is a draft for testing the product and has not had independent fact-checking.